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News briefs

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Md. public works board awards $2 million to wrongfully convicted man

BALTIMORE — The Maryland Board of Public Works awarded over $2 million Wednesday to Anthony Hall, a Baltimore man who served 25 years in prison after being wrongfully convicted of murder.

“Because of this gross miscarriage of justice, Mr. Hall spent 9,072 days behind bars for a crime he did not commit,” Gov. Wes Moore, a Democrat, said at a meeting of the Board of Public Works on Wednesday morning in Annapolis. “It took the state more than three decades to acknowledge Mr. Hall’s innocence.”

Hall, who is now 61, was not present at Wednesday’s meeting. Hall will receive $ 2,360,988 over the next two years under the Walter Lomax Act, and an additional $71,407 for his attorneys’ fees.

In 1992, a 28-year-old Hall was sentenced to 50 years in prison for second-degree murder, unlawful use of a handgun, and wearing a handgun in the commission of the murder of 20-year-old Gerard Dorsey. Dorsey suffered a fatal gunshot wound at the entrance of an alleyway in the Midtown-Edmondson neighborhood of West Baltimore.

—The Baltimore Sun

Officer mistakes acorn for gunshot, unloads on car with man inside

A Florida police officer confused a falling acorn for a gunshot and responded by unleashing a hail of bullets on his own patrol car while a man sat handcuffed inside.

Jesse Hernandez of the Okaloosa County Sheriff’s Office shot up his vehicle after the acorn struck the hood during the Nov. 12, 2023 incident. His partner, Beth Roberts, also opened fire on the vehicle after Hernandez yelled “Shots fired!” and said he had been struck by gunfire.

The handcuffed suspect inside the car, Marquis Jackson, was not struck by any of the bullets.

“Windows were shattering on me the whole time as bullets continued flying across me,” Jackson wrote Feb. 7 on Facebook. “I was blessed not to get hit by any bullets or get hurt physically but mentally, I’m not ok. I haven’t been the same since and I don’t think this feeling I have will ever change.”

—New York Daily News

California lawmakers to visit Israel amid criticism of war in Gaza

SACRAMENTO, Calif. — A group of California lawmakers is on a three-day trip to Israel this week amid growing criticism from U.S. leadership over that country’s conduct in its war against Hamas in Gaza.

In a statement, lawmakers said they will “meet with impacted communities and bear witness to the devastation caused by the Oct. 7 Hamas attack and resulting Israel-Hamas war, both of which have had significant impacts on communities across California.”

Elected officials on the trip include Democratic Sens. Scott Wiener of San Francisco and Henry Stern of Los Angeles, and Democratic Assembly members Jesse Gabriel of Woodland Hills, Esmeralda Soria of Fresno, Damon Connolly of

San Rafael, Josh Lowenthal of Long Beach and Al Muratsuchi of Torrance.

The California delegation said in a statement they will meet Israeli President Isaac Herzog and Arab politicians who are Palestinian citizens of Israel, as well as families of Israeli hostages, advocates for victims of sexual assault and peace activists.

In addition, the statement said they plan to visit kibbutz Kfar Aza, an Israeli community devastated by the Hamas attack, as well as the site of the Supernova Music Festival, where hundreds of young partygoers were killed.

It's unclear whether the lawmakers will be hearing from Gazans or Palestinians living under Israeli military occupation in the West Bank.

—The Sacramento Bee

Study: Results from rapid COVID tests done at home can be trusted

BALTIMORE — People can test themselves about as accurately at home with rapid antigen coronavirus tests as health care professional using the same tests, according to a Johns Hopkins Medicine-led study published online this week.

In the study, which involved nearly 1,000 patients seen at the Baltimore Convention Center Field Hospital during a five-month period in 2022, researchers found that self-administered COVID tests rivaled those administered by clinicians in their ability to determine accurate positive and negative results.

Self-administered tests were 83.9% accurate in determining positive results — compared to 88.2% for clinician-administered tests — and 99.8% accurate in determining negative results, compared to 99.6%.

"We believe this is an important finding because it suggests physicians can feel confident prescribing treatment based on patient-reported, self-administered tests with positive results," study senior author Dr. Zishan Siddiqui said in a Johns Hopkins news release on Tuesday. Siddiqui is an assistant professor of medicine at the Johns Hopkins University School of Medicine.

The study was posted online Tuesday in the American Society for Microbiology journal Microbiology Spectrum.

—The Baltimore Sun

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